

3.2 Population Distribution by Province and District

Sri Lanka's total population is 21,781,800, and its distribution across provinces and districts is presented in Table 3.2.

Table 3.2 : Distribution of Population by Province and District, 2024

Province and District	Population	
	Number	Percentage
Sri Lanka	21,781,800	100.0
Western Province	6,117,341	28.1
Colombo	2,375,415	10.9
Gampaha	2,436,142	11.2
Kalutara	1,305,784	6.0
Central Province	2,714,045	12.5
Kandy	1,461,895	6.7
Matale	526,870	2.4
Nuwara Eliya	725,280	3.3
Southern Province	2,606,679	12.0
Galle	1,097,372	5.0
Matara	837,889	3.8
Hambantota	671,418	3.1
Northern Province	1,150,148	5.3
Jaffna	594,751	2.7
Mannar	123,756	0.6
Vavuniya	172,312	0.8
Mullaitivu	122,619	0.6
Kilinochchi	136,710	0.6
Eastern Province	1,783,214	8.2
Batticaloa	595,918	2.7
Ampara	744,551	3.4
Trincomalee	442,745	2.0
North Western Province	2,586,972	11.9
Kurunegala	1,768,156	8.1
Puttalam	818,816	3.8
North Central Province	1,407,610	6.5
Anuradhapura	960,080	4.4
Polonnaruwa	447,530	2.1
Uva Province	1,399,892	6.4
Badulla	872,307	4.0
Moneragala	527,585	2.4
Sabaragamuwa Province	2,015,899	9.3
Ratnapura	1,145,423	5.3
Kegalle	870,476	4.0

Note: Percentages have been rounded to the nearest one decimal place

When considering the population distribution by province, it is reported that more than one fourth of the total population of the country is from the Western Province, accounting for 28.1 percent. More than 10 percent of the total population is reported from the Central (12.5%), Southern (12.0%), and North Western (11.9%) provinces each. The lowest population is reported from the Northern Province, with 5.3 percent.

Examining the population by district, the highest population is reported from the Gampaha District, which has 2,436,142 persons. The next highest population (2,375,415) is reported from the Colombo District. The district with the lowest population (122,619) is Mullaitivu.

3.3 Population Growth by District

To study population growth at the district level, data from the 2024 Census are presented together with data from the previous census years 1981, 2001, and 2012 in Table 3.3.

Table 3.3 : Population and Average Annual Growth Rate by District, Census Years 1981- 2024

District	Population				Average Annual Growth Rate (%)			
	1981 ²	2001 ³	2012	2024	1981-2001	1981-2012	2001-2012	2012-2024
Sri Lanka	14,846,274	18,797,257	20,359,439	21,781,800	1.2	1.0	0.7	0.5
Colombo	1,675,847	2,239,696	2,324,349	2,375,415	1.4	1.1	0.3	0.2
Gampaha	1,367,813	2,060,470	2,304,833	2,436,142	2.0	1.7	1.0	0.4
Kalutara	823,964	1,065,635	1,221,948	1,305,784	1.3	1.3	1.3	0.5
Kandy	1,032,335	1,276,202	1,375,382	1,461,895	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.5
Matale	352,860	439,031	484,531	526,870	1.1	1.0	0.9	0.7
Nuwara Eliya	583,716	702,689	711,644	725,280	0.9	0.6	0.1	0.1
Galle	805,403	989,769	1,063,334	1,097,372	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.2
Matara	642,235	760,990	814,048	837,889	0.8	0.8	0.6	0.2
Hambantota	421,277	525,913	599,903	671,418	1.1	1.1	1.2	0.9
Jaffna	734,474	-	583,882	594,751	-	-0.7	-	0.1
Mannar	105,276	-	99,570	123,756	-	-0.2	-	1.7
Vavuniya	93,694	-	172,115	172,312	-	2.0	-	0.0
Mullaitivu	73,886	-	92,238	122,619	-	0.7	-	2.2
Kilinochchi	90,778	-	113,510	136,710	-	0.7	-	1.4
Batticaloa	329,343	-	526,567	595,918	-	1.5	-	1.0
Ampara	383,275	592,596	649,402	744,551	2.1	1.7	0.9	1.1
Trincomalee	250,771	-	379,541	442,745	-	1.3	-	1.2
Kurunegala	1,198,795	1,458,385	1,618,465	1,768,156	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.7
Puttalam	485,619	709,002	762,396	818,816	1.9	1.5	0.7	0.6
Anuradhapura	575,546	742,535	860,575	960,080	1.3	1.3	1.4	0.9
Polonnaruwa	253,411	358,804	406,088	447,530	1.7	1.5	1.2	0.8
Badulla	620,839	778,422	815,405	872,307	1.1	0.9	0.4	0.5
Moneragala	269,684	396,521	451,058	527,585	1.9	1.7	1.2	1.2
Ratnapura	779,927	1,016,221	1,088,007	1,145,423	1.3	1.1	0.6	0.4
Kegalle	678,456	784,371	840,648	870,476	0.7	0.7	0.6	0.3

During the period from 1981 to 2024, the population of Sri Lanka increased from 14.8 million to 21.8 million. Considering the census period 2012–2024, the highest average annual growth rate (2.2%) was reported in the Mullaitivu District, which is also reported as the district with the lowest resident population.

² The data for Jaffna and Kilinochchi Districts in the 1981 Census are presented according to the current district boundaries

³ In the 2001 Census, enumeration was not fully completed in the districts of Jaffna, Mannar, Vavuniya, Mullaitivu, Kilinochchi, Batticaloa, and Trincomalee. Therefore, after estimating the population for these districts, the total estimated population for the entire country, as calculated at the end, is reported under 2001.

3.4 Population density

To identify districts where the population is highly concentrated, it is necessary to examine the distribution of the population in relation to land area. In other words, the number of persons living per square kilometer of land area namely, population density should be analyzed. The population densities calculated by district for the census years 1981, 2001, 2012, and 2024 are presented in Table 3.4.

Table 3.4 : Population Density by District, 1981, 2001, 2012 and 2024

District	Population Density (Persons per Square Kilometer)			
	1981	2001	2012	2024
Sri Lanka	230	300	325	350
Colombo	2,605	3,330	3,438	3,551
Gampaha	994	1,539	1719	1776
Kalutara	516	677	775	805
Kandy	554	667	717	780
Galle	487	613	658	695
Matara	516	600	641	648
Jaffna	401	-	629	631
Kegalle	412	466	499	530
Nuwara Eliya	354	412	417	427
Kurunegala	254	316	350	380
Ratnapura	246	314	336	356
Badulla	227	276	288	314
Puttalam	165	246	265	278
Hambantota	164	211	240	273
Matale	180	226	248	268
Batticaloa	134	-	202	251
Trincomalee	98	-	150	181
Ampara	86	140	154	179
Anuradhapura	82	112	129	147
Polonnaruwa	77	117	132	137
Kilinochchi	-	-	94	115
Moneragala	49	72	82	96
Vavuniya	36	-	92	96
Mannar	53	-	53	66
Mullaitivu	39	-	38	51

Note :

- At the time of the 1981 Census, the Jaffna and Kilinochchi Districts functioned as a single district under the name Jaffna.
- In the 2001 Census, enumeration was not fully completed in the districts of Jaffna, Mannar, Vavuniya, Mullaitivu, Kilinochchi, Batticaloa, and Trincomalee. Therefore, after estimating the population for these districts, the population density for Sri Lanka was calculated based on the estimated total population of the country.
- In calculating the population density for 2024, the total land area of the country (67,240 km²), revised in August 2024 and published on the website by the Survey Department, along with the corresponding district land areas prepared accordingly, were used.

In the 1981 Census, the population density of Sri Lanka was 230 persons per square kilometer. By the 2024 Census, this had increased to 350 persons per square kilometer. Compared with 2012, the population density has increased by 25 persons per square kilometer, rising from 325 to 350 persons per square kilometer.

At the district level, the highest population density is reported from the Colombo District. Its population density, which was 2,605, 3,330, and 3,438 persons per square kilometer in the 1981, 2001, and 2012 censuses respectively, has further increased to 3,551 persons per square kilometer in 2024. Following Colombo, the next highest population density is reported from the adjacent Gampaha District, with 1,776 persons per square kilometer.